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David Hargreaves

Life story interview with Paul Thompson

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Principle investigator's thematic highlights

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Professor David H. Hargreaves
Interviewed by Paul Thompson
22 September and 20 October 2009
at the Young Foundation, London

1: Parental commitment

My family is working-class. It was a bit complicated, because my father had worked, during the War, for de Havilland, that made aeroplanes, which had a big aircraft place near Bolton, and then after the War he was a sort of semi-skilled worker. But after the War, my mother's brother-in-law, who ran a kind of newspaper business, tempted my father into doing this, which proved to be a disastrous mistake, so that didn't last very long. And my father was then left without what had been a secure job at de Havilland, and eventually returned as a labourer, which he did then for the rest of his days.

I was the middle of three. I have an elder sister, and she entered the 11+ as one did routinely in those days, and she won a place in Bolton's top school, which was Bolton School. It has two schools, a Boys' School and a Girls' School, and it was a Direct Grant school, and half the places therefore went to kids who got through the 11+. My sister, apparently, was one of the top scorers, and my parents had never thought of that – both of them had left school at 12 or 13 – but my mother, in particular, was keen on education, so my sister went. So then four years later, it came to me to do the 11+, and I too won a place at Bolton School and went. And then three years later, my brother took the 11+ and he also got a place in Bolton School! So three of us ended up at this school!

Life was not easy for my parents because we were relatively poor, and we all had to be kept on to 16 – that was part of the commitment of going to this school, so you couldn't leave, which I would have done if I'd gone somewhere else, earlier, to go to work.... My assumption had been, and my parents' assumption was I would leave school at 16. But the Head of the School called my parents in, and said, "Your son ought to go to university". And my parents said, "Well, no one in our family's ever been to university", and he said, "Well, I think your son should go to Cambridge". And so my parents said, "Okay". And

my mother went out to work to make sure that I could go. My sister had left at 16, but my mother realised that if I was going to go, that means my brother would almost certainly have to go afterwards! So there was a huge commitment that the family had never prepared for...

Had your mother not been working until this happened, then, with the Grammar School?

No, no. She began working to aid the family finances, because my father was earning very little relative to the people I was at school with. She was famous for taking jobs that didn't last very long, but she kept going - but sadly died just after I'd left Cambridge. I think she was just worn out, to be honest, as I look back...

I was closer to my mother, I think. I think we all were. My father was a very good man, absolutely willing to work hard for the family, he wanted the best for us, but he was rather a taciturn sort of man. My mother, I think she was the one who had aspirations for us. She was a great reader in a way my father was not, and she'd quite an interest in the arts, so she followed what we did with great passion....

But as I say, no one had been to university. And, in fact, my brother and I were the only two of that whole generation, on both sides of the family, who got higher education. It changed, of course, with the next generation....

No, there was no resentment at all, there was something of a pride in it, and I had none of the - as I later read, Jackson and Marsden's work about the fate of working-class children. I never experienced any of those kinds of tensions either at Bolton School where, of course, most of my friends were middle-class and professional, or at Cambridge. Maybe I was insensitive to it, or maybe I was fortunate, but I didn't have those problems. (pp. 1-4)

2: Primary school encouragement

One remembers Mrs. Campbell and Mrs. Brown, in the last two classes I was in. They were, of course, old-fashioned primary school teachers that taught conventional literacy and numeracy in a way that became less fashionable in some later periods! (LAUGHS) I

do remember them, and I remember Mrs. Brown, because she encouraged me to write and direct a play, which, as I look back, was probably a very surprising thing. Maybe some of my early interest in writing was beginning to come to the fore, because I always read a lot as a boy, but I loved this idea of writing something, and writing a play, which she encouraged. (p. 5)

3: Bolton Grammar School

Bolton School is a very good school. It was in beautiful buildings. It was a very traditional boys' school, now independent, with teachers wearing gowns, and it was a school that was very rich on the sporting side and on the kind of extra-curricular side....

But nothing really happened until this accident of my being accelerated through to 'O' Level early, and then finding myself in the sixth form very early, at 15, and suddenly realised that French was my best subject, and that you could actually start to think in French, and you could read in French without translating, and suddenly a whole new linguistic and cultural world opened up. The teachers were, by today's standards, I suppose, fairly old-fashioned, but they were immensely able people, very committed, with extremely high expectations, and I think that's maybe its impact on me - their high expectations of me – and I began to realise I was actually enjoying it. I'd not particularly enjoyed school before. I was always in the top set, but I think I was rather a lazy person, basically! If I didn't like something, I didn't do it. But by the sixth form, I was liking it, and I wanted to do it, and I was encouraged by these men with their high expectations of me. And so by the time I went to Cambridge, it almost seemed a natural thing to do, which is odd because it was utterly alien to anything in my family history, but it had begun to seem a natural thing to do....

Perhaps the most influential was a French teacher [Kenneth Haig], who always challenged me, and I would ask him for things. He would say, "Write an essay on Rousseau", and I'd say, "Okay, what books should I read about Rousseau?" And he would say, "Just read some Rousseau and then tell me what you think". And this was really very difficult, you know, for a 16-year old! (LAUGHS) But in many ways he was the most important teacher because he constantly forced me back on my own resources. In fact, when I went

to Cambridge, and I got a First in my first year, I wrote him a letter – the only time I ever wrote to a teacher – and said, "I think this is your influence, because you were the teacher who made me think for myself, gave me some kind of intellectual independence". Now, none of the other teachers did, but they were very good in their ways....

The Head [Richard Poskitt] was crucial. He was a quite remarkable figure, who's much admired by the people of the School.... He was absolutely passionate about working-class kids of the North doing well, but I was only to learn that later. He was a very very strong Cambridge man. He was a very tall man with beautiful silver hair, and a white handkerchief sticking out of his pocket, and he was very grand sort of man. He would tell people - you were called into his study, and he'd tell you where you were going to go. He wouldn't say about university, he'd say, "I think you should go to …",

He taught us for religious education, but in the first year, he was passionate about - he had to know every boy as they joined the School, and he taught in the sixth form. It was allegedly religious education, there was some kind of vague theological theme running through it, but it was really an excuse to talk to the boys and what we would nowadays call General Studies. I mean, he simply wanted boys to talk. And I think, for him, it was important to give young men confidence. I think he was a great believer in people having to be confident in what they were doing....

So in a way, for you, I suppose, he's a model of a successful teacher? Or not?

Well, since I entered teaching later, it wasn't his method of teaching perhaps, so much as a commitment to wanting us to be articulate and independent, and also just civilised - I mean, he would talk about things that we may have known little about. He'd talk about politics, he'd talk about culture, general cultural things. So when I became a teacher, I think it did have an impact on me, that when I taught sixth formers I would expect them to have a working knowledge of key novels or key figures, key intellectual figures. (pp. 5-7. 8-10)

4: From languages to social science

I got in on Modern Languages, but then began to read theology, and that's because I was having problems with my sexual identity – like a lot of gay people in that period. I found that very very difficult to accept, and had a kind of religious conversion. And so I read theology for Part I, and then realised what I was using religion for - which was really to escape a personal problem.

So I wanted to switch, and I had to make a choice, and I was torn between archaeology and anthropology - "Arch and Anth" as it was known in Cambridge – or psychology. I was convinced I wanted to work in the social sciences, but there had been no influence - that I'm aware of - from my childhood. I just got more and more interested in the human condition, and I think that's what appealed to me in literature, but I decided I didn't want to read Modern Languages, and I didn't know enough about either of them to know which I should do. When I looked closely at what they were in Cambridge, in the end I chose psychology because it was a biological science, it was part of the Natural Sciences Tripos in Cambridge, and I thought, "That's going to be an interesting challenge".

I went to see the Professor, called Oliver Zangwill, who was a neuro-scientist, and he said, "We've never had a theologian come before", he said, "but because you got a First, we'll take the risk and take you on". So that's how I ended up in psychology. I could almost as easily have gone to do anthropology. (p. 7)

5: Cross-class friendships

My closest friend is now a very famous person, the actor Ian McKellen. Now, the interesting thing is, of course, we both ended up as gay, but I don't think we were conscious of that at the time. I also had another friend, who also ended up as gay - extraordinarily! We all went to Cambridge. The other friend, a man called Duncan Sculthorpe, died at a very early age, in his twenties. We were in the same class throughout our schooldays – the three of us – until the sixth form, when Duncan became a scientist, but Ian and I went through school together. Ian, by that stage, was clearly going to be a very distinguished actor. ...

It was quite a good year group. Another member of that group was Norman Davies who became a fairly distinguished [European] historian. Ian and I were reasonably friendly with Norman, who was in our year group, but we were not that close, we were closer to another man called Robert Blackburn, who went to Oxford, but we've kept in touch – Ian and I – with Robert, who was a very very gifted musician, and played - in my life - played an important role in helping me to get insights into classical music, which I'm passionate about now, but wasn't part of my family's heritage.

Ian and Robert were both very middle-class. Robert's father was a librarian, chief librarian, Ian's father was the Borough Engineer in Bolton, so was a kind of top dog! And they both lived in kind of exclusive detached houses. But as I look back, the fact that I was friends with them, the class difference, didn't seem to be of any consequence, except I was always conscious of being poorer and I couldn't go on the kind of holidays or the school trips that my other friends went on. (pp. 10-11)

6: Anglo-Catholicism and religion in ferment

Well, I'd been a choirboy and so on, but my family were not particularly religious.... Until I got the bug at about 16!

Well as I look back, of course, it was a solution to my problems. It was kind of a High Churchy Anglicanism, with all the kind of smells and bells and all the theatricality of Anglo-Catholicism, which lasted for about two and a half years.

By the time I got to Cambridge it was beginning to lose its grip on me. Of course, I'd always been intellectually something of a rebel, and I had that reputation at the school as being a bit contrary, and once I got to grips with the theologians, I was questioning just about everything I could find. But, of course, when I got there - to Cambridge – I was exposed to a lot of the German scholars from the late 19th century who'd begun to de-mythologise Christianity, which I find absolutely intriguing. And because I was good at languages I picked up Hebrew and Greek very fast, and was very interested in how we interpreted these texts, but it made one sceptical of conventional religion.

I was fortunate that some of the people who taught me when I first went to Cambridge, were, themselves, challenging people. One of my tutors was Robert Runcie, who later became Archbishop of Canterbury. But the more important influence was a man called Harry Williams, who was Dean of Trinity. I used to see Harry quite often, and he was probably the influence that made me go for psychology rather than anthropology when I had to make that choice, because he was a very liberal thinker, and he was intrigued by all the psychology of religion and said, "Really, we need a lot more people to study the relationships between these. It's a very important field". So they, between them, they encouraged what I was studying with them, fostered my growing scepticism, but it also made me want to study the human condition, more fully than I'd been able to....

That period, the late fifties – I went up in '57 – that was an extraordinary period, of course. It was the period just after Suez, it was the period of Pope John XXIII. Cambridge was, at that stage, in a kind of intellectual ferment, particularly in religious areas. Mervyn Stockwood was the vicar of Great. St. Mary's, and to get into his sermons on a Sunday evening, you had to go three-quarters of an hour before, and the queue would be right round the church! I don't think there's been anything like it since. John Robinson was the Dean of Clare, and wrote *Honest to God*, but almost everybody was talking politics and religion, and so the great thing was, it was a glorious place to work. I loved the University Library, still do to this day. But it meant in your social life, an awful lot was simply talking politics and religion. (pp. 12-13, 15-16)

7: Meeting partner Mohan Mankikar

I think I'd used religion as a kind of protection. That's now accepted much more widely, that this is what a lot of gay people do, why there are so many gay clergy, which was completely unknown to me at that point. I mean, people just didn't talk about these things in those days. I never remember talking to anybody about it at school or at university.... But I simply had to come to the point where I accepted it. I think you do, after a few years. Well, some people go on in denial for, of course, very very much longer, but by my early twenties, I'd accepted it, and I've lived with the same partner for 45 years... We met through music in Manchester. He's of Indian origin. He's a physicist.... We've been together a long time, and we share a lot of common interests, principally in music, about

which I'm very passionate, we're both very passionate, and wider interests in the arts and in reading - we're both voracious readers. (pp. 13-14)

8: Teaching at Hull Grammar School

I taught Religious Education and English. In those days, of course, there was no National Curriculum, you just went in and people said, "Teach whatever you like" – it's bizarre, as I look back! But I enjoyed the work very much, but it was clear I wasn't going to do it for very long.

Why was that?

Well, I remember one day, sitting in the Staff Room, and all the young members of staff sat at one end of this oblong room, and all the Heads of Department sat round the electric fire at the other end, with chairs that were unique to them – you couldn't sit in their chairs, they had their own chairs. And I remember, one day, looking up along the Staff Room, and thinking, "I can see a 40 year trajectory here as I progressively move up the Staff Room and end up with my bum on one of these chairs round the fire!" And I thought, "This is not going to satisfy me!"

Well, in those days it was very much sink or swim. I was an untrained graduate, I could have done a PGC, but everyone told me it was a waste of time, so, of course, I didn't do it. Why would I do something that was a waste of time? So I just walked in, and the bizarre thing was, you were given a class - you were made the form teacher of a set of new boys, when you were completely new to the school! So, of course, they asked me questions to which I didn't know the answers! I didn't even know the geography of the wretched place! But it was sink or swim. A group of people had come in when I did, several young teachers had come in, including several Oxbridge people, and it was sink or swim. You really had to decide you were going to be tough and not let them make a fool of you, or you'd be made a fool of very quickly - which happened to one of us. I was fine, I decided to play it fairly tough, which worked, so that I didn't actually have any real trouble as a teacher, whereas this other chap - who I shared digs with for a period - did,

and never recovered, really, from it, because kids can be very hard on you. But I enjoyed teaching.

So what kind of discipline did you use, then?

Well, you know, you just have to make it clear you're not going to be made a fool of, and if people call your bluff, they try to call your bluff, that's what kids do, and you don't let them get away with anything, and if you do that, you're fine. The school also taught me to play bridge - at lunchtime! ...

And the sixth form, I treated it rather like Richard Poskitt had treated me. It was loosely religious, but it was really about - I suppose I built in a fair amount of social science one way and another – it was about the human condition and our relation to eternity and all that kind of stuff. And, of course, sixth form students are intelligent and interested, and late adolescents, they're fun to talk with, and they're curious, and challenging, so teaching wasn't, in that sense - if you've no discipline problems, teaching in a selective school isn't hard. I mean, it isn't hard at all, if anything, it's insufficiently challenging because it's easy to do – and I wanted more challenge in my life. ...

But there were too many old boys on the staff, for a start, so there was a kind of parochialism which I didn't like. And I thought, "This is not the place where I want to be". And there wasn't all that much going on in the town. Although it was supposed to be a big city, I'd have been much more comfortable in a Manchester or a Leeds, not that I particularly wanted to be in the North, but I wanted a more lively place to be. (pp. 18-20)

9: Research Assistant with Max Gluckman

But then as we were chatting, [Professor Chester] said, "Do you know," he said, "If you've been in a school, there's a job going, upstairs, in Anthropology, studying schools". He said, "Why don't you go up and see Max Gluckman?" (LAUGHS) So I went upstairs and saw Max Gluckman and some of his colleagues, who told me about the work they were doing in schools. And, of course, it was incredibly relevant to what I was doing...

Did you have much to do with Max Gluckman?

Not a lot, because to get close to Max, you had to be a fanatical supporter of Manchester United, and I was not! (LAUGHS) That was the way it was! But I always thought Max was interesting. I mean, he was an incredibly egocentric dominant figure. He was a very big man, and they used to have seminars, and if Max was present, everybody waited to see what Max would say. Max always dominated everything. He was the one to speak first, and he would change direction, he would determine the way. If the seminar was being well-presented, if Max liked it, it went well. If Max didn't like what he heard, it didn't go well. When Max wasn't there, it was a quite different kettle of fish. But, of course, he was a very smart guy, and I'd read all his basic books, being in his Department. But I didn't learn anything kind of directly, it didn't connect to my work. I don't think he was terribly interested in my work...

So I decided, in the end, I would take the job studying schools...

What was this research that they were doing, that you were going to do?

Well, they'd started the project. I was the third person to be added, working on schools. Two had already started – Colin Lacey... and Audrey Lambert. Colin had chosen to work in a grammar school, boys' grammar school in Salford; Audrey went to the girls' grammar school; so the question was, where would I go? What would I study? ... So I thought, "Well, there's only one thing to do, is to go to the absolute opposite end of the scale". (pp. 21-22, 38-39)

10: Observing in a Secondary Modern School

I got on a bike and began cycling around Salford till I found the worst looking school I could find, which was a worn out sec. mod. opposite the docks in Salford, and I went back and said, "I think I should go there". So the Department then arranged a meeting with the Director of Education, and in those days they were rather grand men who Headteachers called "Sir", (LAUGHS) and went to see him, and he called the Head of this secondary modern school in a place called Ordsall, Ordsall Secondary Modern School for Boys. The

Head was called Haggerston, ... and he said, "You'll have this man, Haggerston, in your school, won't you, Haggerston, have this man in your school to study the students?" And then the Head said, "Oh yes. Yes, of course". So this must have been in the summer term, so I duly turned up on the next day, not having a clue what I was going to do. And the Head said, "Well, what do you want to do? I mean, you're here till the end of term". And I said, "I'm sorry, you've got this wrong. I'm here for possibly a couple of years". ...

And that's when I began my ethnography of the school! I just was dumped in, and went along there every morning, and tried to worm my way into a school where everybody was suspicious of this kind of Cambridge guy, who was from the university, and they don't really know what anthropology is, and, "What's he doing in our school, except spying?" (LAUGHS)

Of course, it's the North of England, and people are pretty straightforward, certainly in that part of the world, and if people didn't want me in the class, they would say so, but almost nobody did. And quite quickly I got on with some of the younger staff, who were very interesting, and it became clear that I didn't talk, I didn't gossip about what I'd seen if I sat in on a lesson. You have to prove you're trustworthy as an ethnographer, don't you, and I simply sat and observed and talked, but I didn't gossip, and I think, very quickly people realised that I could be trusted, and then people began to talk to me and tell me things, and so I began to build up a store of knowledge, and rather enjoyed my life. (pp. 22-23)

11: Ethnography and psychology: Erving Goffman and Talcott Parsons

That was a time when people didn't talk about ethnography, they did talk about participant observation, and I'd read a fair bit up. The stuff I'd read before I went in the school was a kind of mixed bag, there was some American stuff. There was Hollingshead's *Elmtown's Youth*, and Wayne C. Gordon's study of a high school, but they didn't particularly turn me on. I'd been much more turned on by James Coleman's *Adolescent Society*, although it was based on survey work, but I felt he was telling me more about what was going on in schools. Apart from that, I'd been reading Albert

Cohen's *Delinquent Boys*, which was about subcultures. I liked him because the Department, it was, of course, Anthropology then – there was no Sociology at that time, it was a pure Anthropology Department – and, of course, they were all experts in Africa and Zulus, but that's what they were always talking about, going to the Sudan, or going to South Africa!

But they were very anti psychology. I don't know why they ever appointed me at all, because if I said something, they'd say, "No, that's psychology. That's not anthropology". But I liked Albert Cohen because he seemed, to me, to be someone who had a psychological element to his study of delinquent boys, whereas I was always having my knuckles rapped for being too psychological, by these very determined anthropologists who wanted no truck with any anthropologist who'd got any element of psychology about them.

I'd read my Evans-Pritchard, and whatever, you know, I read it all very faithfully! So I went armed with that. But one of the most striking books that I read in the period that they allowed me to adjust before I started the work, was Erving Goffman, who was just coming to the fore, and he'd published *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, which was really an exercise in social psychology – "micro sociology" as they were calling it – and *Asylums: A Study of Total Institutions*. And I think, probably, as I look back, in terms of how I was looking at the work, I think I was looking at it through more Goffmanesque eyes than, probably, say Evans-Pritchard or Max Gluckman or whatever they did with their structural functionalism! Yeah, I think that was kind of influencing how I felt, and I think it was the social psychological strand to that, and the fascination by the relationships which intrigued me. Of course, it related back to my own experience as a teacher, knowing that, as a teacher, you've two sets of relationships to master – those with your colleagues, and those with the kids – and if you make a hash of either of those, you're in trouble, and you've got to succeed at both. So that's the kind of orientation I went with. ...

I forgot to say a big influence on my orientation had been Talcott Parsons. Now, Talcott Parsons, generally, was totally unreadable, as far as I was concerned! I couldn't understand why anybody was ploughing through *The Social System*, and some of those great books that he wrote that were still pretty fashionable! But he'd published a little

article called, "The School Class as a Social System", which was widely reproduced, and it was a very clever piece, saying what the function of school is, to differentiate human beings who have not been differentiated by mothers, who take a highly particularistic stance - you use Parsons' scheme, I can't remember it all, what we call the "pattern variables" - the mothers look at their children as unique and so on, but the moment you get to school you've got be differentiated, and Parsons quite rightly said you're differentiated along two axes, one is an intellectual academic one – kids are bright or dull, high or low achievers – and the moral one about whether you behave well and so on, and these two axes are the basis of how schools - how the classroom differentiates it. But, of course, what I'd seen as a grammar school teacher, was how it worked across the school, because the A streams were treated very much better in Hull Grammar School than were the D streams, and, of course, this replicated itself in the sec. mod. because almost all schools were then streamed, and streaming was the differentiating mechanism. (pp. 24-16)

12: On mixed methods

I'd hated statistics as an undergraduate, but suddenly when I wanted to know whether a difference was significant or not, by God I was interested in statistics, as I worked it all out by hand. But I felt I was accumulating evidence and that that was going to be important to me.

I think the position is not so much about a commitment to mix methods, but that mixed methods is a means of achieving the end of a better evidence base. It was about, "What's the evidence base for what you're saying?" And I kept thinking, "Anthropologists, they could be inventing some of this. They could be sitting around the wigwams or whatever they were doing, you know, in various parts of the world, listening to the gossip and so on," and I used to go to these seminars and they'd say they'd sat around some tribe for a long time, and then this is what they come out with about the kinship structures, and all these joking relationships, a lot of the stuff that anthropologists talk about, and I used to worry about, "Well, they might have invented that. How widespread was it? And how did they know people were telling them the truth? ...

But, of course, the same thing was true, to some degree, of Goffman. I mean, Goffman was just an acute observer. So I think one of the things I learnt, the positive things I learnt from the anthropologists, and from people like Goffman, was to observe closely – which I think I had not learnt as a psychologist. But I had learnt, as a psychologist, to question your evidence base. So for me, it was bringing that together. (pp. 26-27)

13: Gaining trust as an ethnographer

Well, I used to go into classrooms before the teacher had arrived. I mean, the first test they put to me, was trying to make me behave like a teacher, and I had to learn to take a blind eye, I couldn't approve of what they were doing when they were misbehaving, but I couldn't be seen to be stopping it, unless I thought somebody was in desperate danger. The biggest difficulty was with the cock of the school, the boy in the lower streams, who I called "Clint" in the book, who was a very tough boy, and he was respected because he was the best fighter and he had his gang round him, and, of course, they were very very suspicious of me. But they used to go out at lunchtime and go to the Billiard Hall, and I remember at one stage, I said, "Can I come to the Billiard Hall?" and they let me go with them to the Billiard Hall, and I sat in while they watched adults off the docks playing billiards. And this was their future, this is what they dreamed of, they wanted to be grown up and smoke.

So gaining trust is a long slow business, isn't it? You can say, "I won't tell anybody what I've seen", but nobody believes that until long afterwards and they know that you've kept your word. ... I think, as an ethnographer, the quality you most need, often, is patience, because moments will come when you'll witness something, or something will be said, or you'll get a chance to say something to somebody, and you'll get pure gold, but then there may be days when nothing seems to happen. I went on a few school trips, for example, with the kids, because then the staff are more relaxed, and the kids are more relaxed, and you can learn quite a lot then – not least from the teachers... You see, you become part of the furniture, as an ethnographer, after a while. (pp. 27, 29)

14: The ethics of publishing ethnography

How did the teachers react to the manuscript, in the end?

Oh, there was a really - they were divided down the middle. I'd very carefully tried to mask them and the school, and most of the staff material I'd discarded on ethical grounds. I particularly could say very little about the Headteacher because it would be obvious it was him, and the same applied to the Deputy Head, so I said much less than people would say nowadays. But there was a sense that I was portraying the school in a bad way and that was wrong – that was the negative half. The positive half said, "This is great, you're telling it like it is, and people don't tell stories about schools like they are, and you should absolutely go ahead". So in the end, I said, "Look, any errors of fact, or anything that you think would betray a trust, tell me, and I'll remove them". And I removed a few things.

But I found, interestingly, that then most people were guessing some of the quotations. And I'd say, "Where are you quoted in it?" They'd get it wrong! They'd attribute to themselves things they'd never said, and attribute things they'd said to other people! So that was kind of interesting! So it shows I'd covered it up pretty well actually. Of course, the boys, I couldn't consult. But that was that. (p. 30)

14: Conflicting cultures within a school

The International Editor [of Routledge and Kegan Paul] was W.J.H. Sprott, who was, of course, a social psychologist. And Sprott wrote back and said, "We'll publish it". And that's when my life changed...

Is the book, to some extent, a study of two conflicting cultures between the students within the school?

Oh yes, I mean, there were two competing cultures. I'd felt that was, to some degree, true in the grammar school where I'd taught...

But was the book novel in studies of schools, in having that kind of perspective?

Perhaps putting it quite so sharply, yes, but there were fictional accounts of Partridge, and Edward Blishen and things that had captured some of that. I think perhaps putting it in the way I did. I think it's the book people have talked most to me about in subsequent years, and, in fact, twice in the last two weeks, a Headteacher – I did a lot of work with Heads still – has mentioned the book to me, people I've never met before. I think it's because at the time, a lot of people said, "This could be our school". It had had some kind of ring of authenticity. Now, whether it was the two cultures, or whether it was something about the way teachers behave and talk, and the way kids do things and so on to some degree, this differentiation amongst the kid - the polarisation into cultures - they come out more sharply than was true in the Parsons' study. Because the Parsons' study was a very cool, intellectual, analytic piece – very low on a sense of what it feels like to be in the school. And I think there weren't many things around, so it got adopted quickly as a course book for teacher training, because it was about a real school, and real kids were talking. Though it certainly was an extreme, I chose there because it was kind of extreme. But people saw resonances, as I, myself, saw resonances right to the grammar school. (pp. 31, 34)

16: Interpreting and prescribing? The influence of early research

I think my job there was to understand and be faithful to what I was seeing. In that sense, I was perhaps being quite a good anthropologist, was I? Yes! Rather than an educationist.

It seems like it's the correct anthropological position, but doesn't fit with what you later go on to do, which is to tell people how to change things!

(LAUGHS) No, because that's why I said the book changed my life... I'd want to argue some of the things I learned, and some of my ways of looking at the world and at life, that started with that study in Lumley [Ordsall], are with me to this day. To this day. I mean, it's imprinted itself on me. It's a stamp for life...

Which aspects, in particular, are stamped on you for life?

An obsession with people, not systems, even when I talk about systems. A concern with authenticity and evidence. A concern always to relate what you say somehow back to people and their lives... When you take a full-time job as a lecturer, you can't go on being an ethnographer, ... still when I've been given a chance, I've gone back and done ethnographic type work, even in very different settings, like hospitals... [But] that was the first change in my life – I knew I couldn't go on doing endless Lumleys as it were.

But the second was, I was now in a field where I was talking about how the world should be, because that's what education is about. Education has to have a strong prescriptive element, and so I was pushed into a world where I was having to say, not just "This is the way the world is", but "This is the way the world perhaps could and should be". I suppose I've had to live with that tension, in a way that if I'd not been in an applied Department – as education is always an applied social science – if I'd stayed in mainstream sociology or anthropology I probably would have looked at it differently. (pp. 35-36)

17: On politics

What, on my political views? Well, the only thing to say is I'm not a - I've never been a joiner. I have no sense of loyalty to a group, and I'm deeply suspicious of any group which would want to command my loyalty ... My politics have swung around - I suppose broadly centre, and more often left of centre than right of centre, but I've not been a joiner. I loved politics, I loved the cut and thrust, I loved working in London, I loved my time when I was a Policy Advisor to Estelle Morris, and when I knew Charles Clarke, and I knew three Secretaries of State in Education very well, and I loved being close up to politics, but I was never truly part of it. (p. 40)

18: Giving voice to informants as evidence

You talk about using the boys' own words, which was possible, because you'd done this tape-recording. Would you like to say any more about why do that?

Well, for me, it was about the quality of the evidence base. Most of the stuff I was reading in the Anthropology Department didn't actually quote anybody. You described what people did, and so on, and people would say, "Somebody was an informant", but you would very rarely see a chunk of text. But to me, my saying somebody had said something to me is not the same as quoting the precise words that I could actually document. ... So I wanted two things the Department didn't want me to do – they didn't want me to have lots of statistics, and they didn't want lots of quotes, but I regarded both as crucial to my story. ... But I've used a tape-recorder ever since in everything I've done. (pp. 41-42)

19: Ethnomethodology, phenomenology and labelling theory

The Goffman School was a continuing influence, but people like Anselm Strauss had become very important.... And I was becoming increasingly interested in phenomenonology and ethnomethodology.

And who, there?

Well, inevitably Garfinkel and Sachs and all those people were interesting in ethnomethodology, and a great debate was going on about were these guys really completely bonkers and about to ruin the whole of the sociological enterprise – which was certainly never my view. I always thought they were basically in the social psychological terrain, but not really in classical sociology terrain, but I could see links to socio-linguistics and so on. The minutiae of interaction have always interested me, as a social psychologist, so it was natural. ...

But a growing interest was Howard Becker, and Howard Becker had actually written some interesting things on education, which is how I first came across his work, as I recall, but then he became, he was becoming a much more central figure in deviance theory, and labelling theory in particular, and he'd done the work on marijuana, the big book *Outsiders* and so on, which I began using with students, and there was a growing interest in difficult children, therefore deviance theory began to come up. Now, the work

in England of Stan Cohen and people like that, Laurie Taylor to some degree, one or two others, was a wee bit marginal to the kind of stuff I was doing with students in education, but the labelling theory stuff seemed enormously relevant...

Well, all that seemed to lead back naturally to the kids who most concerned me - the kids who get on the wrong side of teachers. But we weren't doing what, I suppose, a conventional sociologist would have done, we weren't interested, as it were, in the objective issue about whether these kids [had] something wrong with them, or the kind of pathological models, we were simply interested in the processes of how they came to be labelled, and what the consequences of that were. There's a fairly strictly Becker outsider type view with some phenomenological bits added.

So I thought one of the best bits of that book, we were struggling with how teachers rather than avoid the word simply "labelling" the child as Becker had done, what were the basic typifications that teachers used to make sense of children's behaviour? And so we spent a lot of time that depended on watching teachers handle kids in classroom situations, but back again to interviews saying to teachers, "Here's a list of your kids, what sort of a pupil is she?" "What do you think of him?" And they began to specify it... So we began probing, as it were, how people came to characterise kids, which I think had been taken for granted in most of the educational literature up to that point. The assumption was teachers simply had appropriate labels for kids, that were warranted, but they hadn't unmasked the nature of the evidence base, as it were, that teachers were using, and how they did it. So we were playing with a lot of things that happened, because teachers routinely quite quickly typified children as being of a particular type, and what the consequences are.

And that was in contrast to the mainstream Sociology of Education which was going through a very big neo-Marxist phase, so once again I was finding myself in peripheral position, fiddling around with these typifications (LAUGHS), based on ethnography, and most of the sociologists that I was working with, and knew, were dealing with these huge macro things about capitalist society.... (pp. 45-46, 48-49)

20: Deviance in Classrooms: Interpreting ethnography and grounded theory

Could you describe what kind of ethnography you were doing for this project?

It's sitting around watching, talking, interviewing, recording. By that stage I was beginning to discover that if you do ethnography, you have to have a knack of deciding what's the really important thing you're dealing with, and what kind of patterns you can see. So there's a conceptual task, you've got make sense of the data, and the danger of ethnography is you just collect piles of stuff, and it doesn't add up.... [It's through] partly field experience, but partly, I think, reading, having a lot of stuff in your head from really great writers, that you can start to conceptualise. You begin to see some shapes or you begin to get hypotheses, or you get an idea and you suddenly realise a concept is growing out of it, and you can see a way of marshalling the data, and decanting a lot of it – because you have to decant it, and it's not because it's rubbish, because it doesn't fit your emerging conceptual scheme.

There was stuff being written about this, like Glaser and Strauss, and grounded theory and all that, but I could never quite cope with it, because they tried to make it out - they were writing, the same with Anselm Strauss, writing guides to fieldwork, at this time – they began doing that, and I found these okay, but they made it sound very rational and logical and plannable. I found I couldn't work as a social scientist in that way. I would have ideas in the middle of the night, they'd pop out of nowhere into my head, and I'd suddenly think, "That might be a way of making sense of that"...

So it was that kind of ethnography. We were collecting material, but you slowly have to start beaming in on something, and to do that you've got to start conceptualising it. So the book kind of gets written, and then you do start to go back and amplify and develop, and find more transcript material that fits. Or, as some of the field books were then saying, you've got to try and find instances where it doesn't fit, and find out why it doesn't fit. Are these exceptions? Is it still part of the story, but the story's more complicated than you thought it was? (pp. 48-49, 51-52)

21: Language codes and Basil Bernstein

I thought [his work] was pretentious and over-rated, to be honest. I never understood why he had such an elevated reputation. The interesting thing was, if you look at Bernstein's very early papers, they are very straightforward and they are very clear. And as he went on they got more and more obscure. I was also working with the ESRC at that point, and people were writing critiques of Bernstein, and every time anyone said anything, his reply was, "They've got it completely wrong. They've misunderstood me", and his next bit would be even more obscure than the bit that was being criticised! So I thought he started off with some fairly interesting stuff about the codes, and about particularly working-class language in educational settings – some of which made a lot of sense to me – but then it became so elaborate, I simply lost patience with it. (p. 56)

22: The Challenge of the Comprehensive School: Different forms of ability

What became one of the most quoted bits in the book, is when I talked about the different forms of abilities that are valued by the school, with the academic at the top. If I called them "intelligence", different kinds of intelligence, I'd have probably been more famous because I'd have been doing what Howard Gardener did later! But I was really saying that the schools value certain kinds of abilities – the bit that people remember was because I said how hopeless I was at woodwork and metalwork at school, but there was a real important human ability, and I was hopeless at it, and my vision of hell was a school that was entirely dominated by a curriculum that was woodwork and metalwork, and occasionally I might have been allowed a bit of French - and I was trying to bring out that the school is highly selective in what it values, and it doesn't recognise the wide range of human abilities. And that struck a chord with a lot of people, because the comprehensive school had, in practice, meant the imposition of largely grammar school values on a total system, so it kind of rang bells. And there were interesting questions about what kind of knowledge and skills. It's still around today – what are they trying to inculcate, for whom, and why, with what success? ...

These different kinds of ability – actually became the first pages of what became *The Hargreaves Report*, where I talked about four forms of achievement. Though we were still back to this question of, "What does school value? What the kids bring? What's the purpose of it all?" And ironically – I thought it was just an introduction – it became the most quoted bit of the whole Report! (pp. 58-61)

23: Chief Inspector for ILEA: academics and practical policy

Since I've never run a corner shop in my life, never run anything, and suddenly I had a staff of 600, and a £25m. budget at my disposal – it was a bit of a shock! ... Tessa Blackstone [said to me], "You are going to have to make decisions on very little evidence, and the academic in you will say, 'I can't make that decision until I know some more'", and she said, "You won't be able to". And it was profoundly right. You kept having to make decisions and then live with the consequences.

But, I mean, it was real, it was the real world. I began to discover what it was really like, and I began to discover why – and then reported it back, later, to colleagues – why academic research was making such relatively little impact on practical policy-making, and there were good reasons why it wasn't, and it wasn't, as it were, our fault. I mean, it was the academics' fault – I put most of the blame with the academics. It confirmed my feeling that the writing was too obscure, it was too difficult, there was no real attempt to communicate with people and talk it through. (pp. 61-62)

24: Observing how doctors learn

[In 1995] the post-graduate Dean came to see me and explained that what was happening with the training of junior doctors was a thing known as "Calmanisation". Calman was the Chief Medical Officer [in Cambridge]... We had to align, in the UK, the training of junior doctors with Continental Europe, and we were taking about twice as long to train a consultant as the Continent was. People preferred our system because it was a longer training, but we had to conform. So the question was, they decided they would pretty well halve the length of the training period.... And he came to see me and said, "We've

been given no additional resources, we're just going to have to improve the quality of teaching". So I said, "Okay".

I said, "Well, first of all, we need to find out what people are actually doing – what the consultants do". So my natural inclination was to go and observe... So I got a small team together, and I was the only one that was willing to do surgery, because nobody wanted to work in operating theatres. But I'd been in them as a student – as I think I explained, I worked in hospitals in my vacations, because my brother-in-law and my sister worked in hospitals – so there was no problem, I'd been in operating theatres. So I started there with some orthopaedic surgeons, who I persuaded to let me stand around, and I also looked at them in the major settings where surgeons work, namely operating theatres, clinics, and ward rounds, and I trailed after them.

And when I asked them how they trained their juniors, they said, "Well, it's an apprenticeship" – that was the most common word I came across, and the other one was, "They pick it up by osmosis"! (LAUGHS) [They meant] just by standing around and watching. There's always a joke among surgeons, "Watch one, do one, teach one"! (LAUGHS) So you're supposed to be able to pick it up! You know, you just pick it up. And this word "osmosis" came up really quite a lot. And so that, of course, confirmed me that I just had to stand around and watch what they were doing.

They all had their own - it was a highly idiosyncratic thing because it was so informal, and effectively some of them would simply give like little lectures, or almost ignore the junior. The junior just trailed along and watched. As they got a little bit older, they would assist. Others were very very skilful at cross-questioning their juniors, particularly on ward rounds or in clinics.

Then, following my earlier instinct, I wanted their actual words, and this was going to be quite tricky, because in operating theatres, you're gowned, it's very difficult even to make notes. It was difficult to hear what they were saying as they were poring over the operating table. I could only get reasonably close. So I persuaded them to wear microphones, and they had a little microphone stuck in their cap! (LAUGHS) I was desperately hoping it wouldn't fall out into the patient! And it was trailed down the back of their green gowns, and they tucked the battery into their back pocket. And then I

recorded and it was quite good, it picked up what the surgeon said and what the junior said. I tried that there, and I tried it in several hospitals, including Papworth where they were doing heart transplants.

Then, of course, I did interviews with the consultants and with the juniors, and I did a survey of the juniors, and then combined that all.

You mean a questionnaire type survey you're talking about?

Yes, a questionnaire survey type survey, yeah. So it was pretty well what I'd done at the Lumley Study, a generation earlier, and just repeated all the techniques I felt comfortable with, and moved back and forth between them. So I did interviews and then I would do a bit of a questionnaire bit, and then the questionnaire would alert me to certain things.... Yes, open-ended, and they would fill it in. Whenever you're hanging around. There's quite a lot of hanging around in hospitals, when juniors have nothing particular to do, the hours are long – but nobody seemed to mind being interviewed. It wasn't always easy to get them to agree to my going in the first place, some specialties refused, but the orthopods were very very good, and I just went to orthopaedics in several hospitals.

Then the question was, what were we going to do? Well, of course, we're being paid to improve the training. One was we produced a training pack for the people in each hospital who are responsible for training. There's a person called the Clinical Tutor, who was a consultant in any field, who accepts a kind of responsibility for the overall training...

It was clear that the key method of improving teaching was to improve the questioning: some were very good, and some were utterly hopeless at questioning their juniors. They simply wouldn't ask any questions, or they'd ask a few closed questions. They wouldn't ask questions that required them to think. They'd point to something and say, "Which nerve is that?", in the operation, or, "Where would you cut?" and so on. They didn't ask really powerful questions.

A powerful question would require them to do cognitive work, so they would say, "What are the options at this point?" And then the junior has to think very hard about what the options are, because they've all got to be reasonable options, and if it's a good question,

it'll be a point where there's probably one particularly favourable option, but there are other things that could be done under certain circumstances. So what we did was produce books on the training of juniors, *On the Job Training* we called it, and produced two books – one for surgeons and one for physicians. (pp. 69-73)